case. According to her, the daughter may not be dead at all. She mentions a sighting at Guwahati airport of someone who might be the missing girl. There seems to be no credible motive. Strangulation as a method seems too bizarre for even the most demonic of mothers.

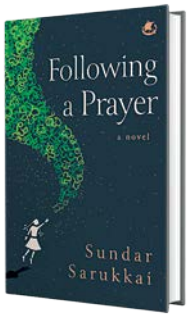
Mukerjea's authorial voice is thick with clichés of the "pale as a ghost" kind. If not for the incendiary subject matter, she might be writing high school essays. Her portrait of family life is devastating in the crude banality of conversations, the fixation on money and property. However unbroken the author claims to be, she leaves the reader shuddering with distaste. And pity. ■

**Manjula Padmanabhan**

BOOKS

# The Sound of Silence

**Sundar Sarukkai's *Following a Prayer* tackles some fundamental philosophical questions**




**FOLLOWING A PRAYER**
*by Sundar Sarukkai*
TRANQUEBAR/ WESTLAND BOOKS
₹**599; 244** pages

Where do words go? What does it mean to follow a sound? Is 'God' just another word or our collective shorthand for 'illusion'? Or is language itself the root cause of lies? These questions sound like they belong at a philosophy seminar, but in Sundar Sarukkai's brilliant and highly unusual novel *Following a Prayer*, such are the queries posed by children mounting a valiant attempt to make sense of a disorienting world. Twelve-year-old Kalpana disappears into a nearby forest for three days after deciding to obey a casual utterance by her praying grandmother, urging her to 'follow the prayer'. Upon her return, she refuses to speak, confounding her family, her teachers and the village at large—their possible explanations range from mystery viruses to violent crimes to divine intervention.

But it's Kalpana's younger sister Deeksha and her precocious, polio-stricken classmate Kumari who take the time and effort to communicate with Kalpana on her own turns. And in doing so, they become Tolstoy's 'little girls wiser than men' (from the eponymous short story), picking away at the fuzzy, Wittgenstein-adjacent logic that transforms sounds into words and words into language. The novel's midsection, then, plays out as a kind of playful, elusive catechism at the intersection of linguistics and philosophy. The remarkable thing is that the author pulls this off without making these children sound like Mensa prodigies who've swallowed several encyclopaedias. Fittingly, Sarukkai accomplishes this thanks in no small part to his own nimble use of language.

This is a novel that's dense with ideas, sometimes to its own peril. But for the most part, Sarukkai handles the intellectual and spiritual curiosity of his juvenile characters deftly and with respect. A teacher of philosophy himself, Sarukkai also has a great deal to say about pedagogy and the ennui that can prevent teachers from communicating with young students efficiently (in 2021, he published a children's book called *Philosophy for Children*). In the winter of 2013, I was lucky enough to listen to the author in person, in a lecture titled 'Thinking and Learning in the Age of Maggi Noodles', where he impressed upon the audience the importance of slow and deliberate thinking in an era of instant gratification. I exited the lecture hugely impressed by the elegance of Sarukkai's arguments. And now that I've finished *Following a Prayer*, I want to read everything the author's ever written. ■

**Aditya Mani Jha**

factors beyond their control. At the same time, the collapse of centralised power did not necessarily create chaos. Instead, it could lead to more sustainable, democratic modes of living.

*The Earth Transformed* makes this argument in a Big Book. Like geographer Jared Diamond and historian J.R. McNeill's tomes, this one is hugely ambitious in its scope too. Its 650 pages of text detail the history of the world "from the dawn of time". Though the scale is daunting, Frankopan manages to craft a coherent narrative without dumbing down the complexity of what he describes. Even more impressive is his marshalling of staggering amounts of data: the references run to 212 pages (they are not included in the book, but are available on the publisher's website). Pulling together evidence from studies ranging from geology to linguistics, Frankopan knits an intricate picture of, for example, the Black Death in 14th-century Eurasia, which brings in volcano eruptions in Japan and Iceland, Mediterranean droughts, Mongols, and marmots. However, the sheer volume of contending facts sometimes gets out of hand. Instead of elucidating how the world is ordered, the book seems to confirm chaos theory: complex systems are unpredictable. Even if we discern patterns in our rear-view mirror, they don't tell us how to steer towards the future.

**PETER FRANKOPAN** manages to craft a coherent narrative without dumbing down the complexity of what he describes

If that is so, the lessons of history are far more elusive than we might hope for. All our data, the growth of scientific knowledge, illuminates our ignorance rather than our wisdom. We have more facts about how the biophysical world works and shapes human history. Yet, these advances only impress upon us how little we know.

It is creditable that *The Earth Transformed* tries to be truly global, not Eurocentric. It's also commendable that a book that places the environment in the foreground avoids ecological determinism. Here and there, it gets facts wrong. Sometimes, it is cryptic and contradictory. On the whole, however, this is a book that will inform, if not enlighten. ■

**Amita Baviskar**